

V11 Addressing Workload Struggles Openly

Pillar	Vulnerability	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	45-55 minutes	Group Size	4-10
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	V1 or V8 completed (trust needed to discuss workload honestly)	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Burnout indicators, workload imbalance signals, declining quality, missed deadlines, team members not flagging capacity issues

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Chronic overload sustains elevated cortisol, which progressively shuts down the prefrontal cortex's capacity for planning, prioritisation, and creative problem-solving. The tragic irony: the brain functions needed to solve workload problems are the first things cortisol destroys. People who are overwhelmed become worse at managing their workload, creating a downward spiral.

Admitting workload struggles activates the brain's social threat system (fear of appearing incompetent, fear of being seen as not coping). This is why most people don't raise workload concerns until they are already in crisis. The vulnerability required to say 'I'm struggling' must be explicitly made safe.

When a team creates a structured, normalised way to discuss workload, two things happen neurologically. First, the act of naming the problem reduces the amygdala's threat response (labelling emotions and states has a measured calming effect on the brain). Second, collaborative problem-solving activates oxytocin pathways, shifting the experience from 'I'm drowning alone' to 'we're solving this together.'

Before You Begin

PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY CHECK

This exercise can backfire if the manager is part of the workload problem (assigning too much, not prioritising, not shielding the team from unnecessary requests). Before running this, honestly assess: am I contributing to the overload? If so, acknowledge it at the start of the exercise. Pretending the problem is purely about task management when it is actually about management behaviour will destroy trust.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Honest Workload Check (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"I'm going to ask everyone a direct question and I want an honest answer, not a brave one. On a scale of 1-5, where 1 is 'I have capacity' and 5 is 'I'm underwater,' where are you right now? Write it down. Then write down the one thing that's contributing most to that number."

Collect numbers on the flipchart (anonymous if needed for first time). The manager shares their own number first. Seeing the aggregate picture often shifts the conversation from individual complaint to team reality.

Phase 2: Making It Visible (15 minutes)

Each person briefly shares their top contributor (the one thing driving their workload number). The manager captures these on the flipchart/Miro and groups them:

- Things the team controls (internal processes, task allocation, meeting load)
- Things the manager controls (priorities, stakeholder management, shielding from requests)
- Things neither controls directly (organisational demands, external deadlines, resource constraints)

FACILITATION NOTE

The critical skill here is preventing this from becoming a complaint session. After each share, ask: "Is this something we can change, influence, or do we need to accept it and manage around it?" This question moves the conversation from venting to problem-solving.

Phase 3: The Manager's Honest Response (5 minutes)

This is the moment that determines the exercise's credibility. The manager must respond honestly to what they've heard.

WHAT TO SAY (ADAPT TO YOUR REALITY)

"Here's what I'm hearing. [Summarise the key themes.] Some of this I can act on immediately, and I will. [Name specific actions.] Some of this I need to escalate because it's beyond what I can fix alone. [Name those.] And some of this, honestly, is not going to change in the short term, and I owe you honesty about that rather than false promises."

Do NOT promise what you cannot deliver. A single broken promise after this exercise will prevent anyone from raising workload concerns again.

Phase 4: Building the Pressure Valve (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"This shouldn't be a one-time conversation. What mechanism do we want for raising workload

concerns between now and the next time we do this? Something simple that doesn't require scheduling a meeting or writing a formal escalation."

Common mechanisms: a standing 2-minute check at the start of weekly team meetings ("Anyone above a 3 this week?"); a shared signal (red/amber/green status on a shared board); explicit permission to DM the manager with a capacity flag.

Whatever the team chooses, the manager must respond to it consistently. If someone flags and nothing happens, the mechanism dies.

Phase 5: Close (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Here's my commitment. I will [specific actions promised]. And I will check back with each of you in our next 1:1 about how your workload number is tracking. If it's going up, I want to know before you're at a 5, not after."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Everyone says they're fine (all 1s and 2s) when the CLOVER ERA data suggests otherwise	Name the gap directly: "Our engagement data is showing some workload signals that suggest the picture might be different. I'm not here to call anyone out. I'm here because I'd rather hear about it from you than from a dashboard. But if the timing isn't right, we can revisit." If the gap persists, the trust issue is the primary problem to solve. Go back to V1.
One person dominates with their workload complaints while others stay silent	After they finish, redirect: "Thank you. I want to make sure I hear from everyone. Who else is carrying something they haven't mentioned?" Use written input if verbal sharing is blocked.
The discussion reveals the manager is the primary source of overload	Do not get defensive. Say: "I hear that. I need to look at how I'm assigning work and what I can do differently. Give me a week to come back with specific changes." Then follow through.
The team identifies problems but there are genuinely no solutions available	Be honest: "I can't fix this one right now. What I can do is make sure you know that I know it's a problem, and I'll flag it upward. In the meantime, what can we do to make it more manageable even if we can't make it go away?"

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
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During the session	Workload numbers are honest (a team at genuine capacity doesn't report all 1s and 2s) The manager's honest response lands (visible relief or nodding) The pressure valve mechanism is something the team actually wants to use
Within 1-2 weeks	Someone uses the pressure valve mechanism A team member flags a capacity issue before it becomes a crisis The manager follows through on committed actions
CLOVER ERA data (2-4 weeks)	Vulnerability scores increase (people feel safe raising concerns) Enablement scores may improve (workload barriers are being addressed) Burnout indicators stabilise or improve
Red flags	If workload numbers increase after the session and nothing changes, the exercise created awareness without action. The manager must deliver on commitments.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V1: Vulnerability Circle	V1 builds the trust that makes honest workload conversations possible.	Run V1 before V11
V9: Cultivating Empathy	Empathy prevents workload discussions from becoming competitive suffering. Team members need to hear each other's struggles without comparing.	Run V9 before V11
E9: Removing Outdated Processes	Workload discussions often surface process barriers. E9 provides the framework for removing them.	Follow V11 with E9 for process-related workload issues
R1: Micro-Reflection	Brief reflection check-ins can serve as the pressure valve mechanism between V11 sessions.	Complementary